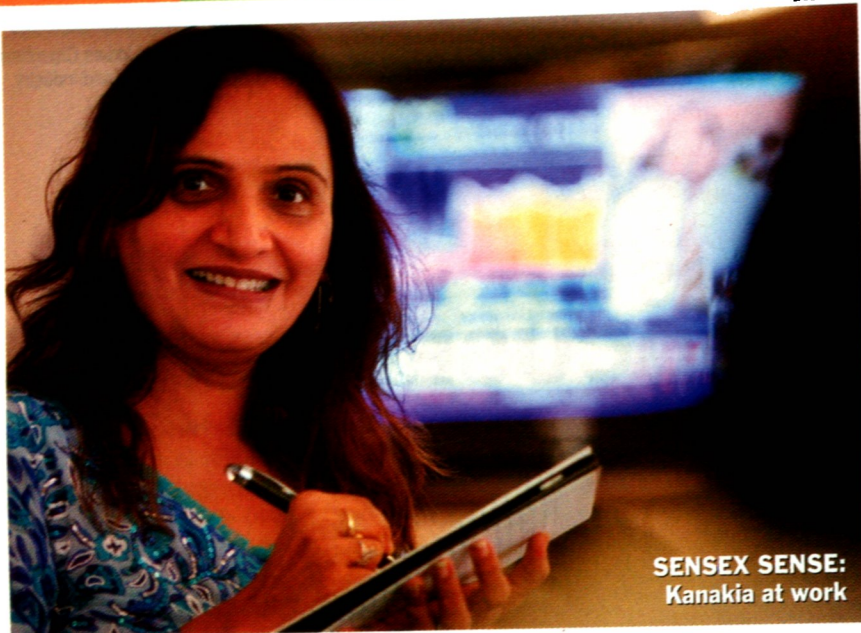




STOCK MARKET



Mumbai | MAHARASHTRA

Scaling the peaks

■ By Malini Bhupta

Deepa Kanakia, 45, isn't your typical career woman. Fourteen years ago she decided to storm one of the toughest male bastions of her time—the stock market. While her friends discussed fashion and her two children were away at school, Kanakia spent hours at a brokerage in her neighbourhood. Initial losses kept her away from the stock market till 2000, but Kanakia re-entered the thick of things by opening a dematerialised account for her shares and a broking account. "Everything is very transparent and in a dematerialised form there is no risk in today's market," she says. Rather than following the advice of her broker, she started making trips to the broking outfit, striking deals herself.

Every time she'd make a small profit, she would keep it aside and invest in delivery stocks, primarily blue chips which she wanted to hold on to for the long term. Her husband, a chartered

The stock market story is not just about blue chip firms accumulating capital but also of small investors who have ascended with its rise

accountant, encouraged her to keep her interest alive. Her first investments were in Cipla and Wipro. Today her portfolio has 25 firms and its net asset value is Rs 20 lakh. Not bad for someone who started with nothing. The share market has become much simpler, now that it is online. Even as she is well on her way to becoming an expert, Kanakia still goes to her broker's office every morning and monitors the market. Seven months ago, she joined Sunidhi Investments as a sub-broker. "It's critical to monitor the market and the performance of companies. the

broker can only be a good guide," she says, adding, "Now, I advise other women to invest in the capital markets." With the number growing, it's no wonder that Kanakia is busy.

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CHANGING FACE OF IAS
Mussoorie | UTTARAKHANDThe
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Niranjan Kumar's journey from a small village in Madhubani to the IAS academy in Mussoorie symbolises the transformation in the civil services

■ By Shyamlal Yadav

Twenty kilometres from the bustling city of Darbhanga is Sakari, a small village in Madhubani, Bihar. Niranjan Kumar is familiar with the route—it is one he used to take every day by train to attend college. It was a trip worth making, its dividends high. Coming from a family where higher education was a precious commodity—two sisters dropped out of school early and his mother is illiterate—Kumar never travelled beyond Bihar's borders till the age of 22, when he visited Delhi. Kumar never let his disability, he is hearing impaired, hamper his dream that included appearing for one of the toughest examinations in the country, the civil services. "I prepared for it, but never thought I would reach so far," he says.

Now training at the Lal Bahadur Shastri Academy for Administration at Mussoorie, the road from Sakari has been rocky. When his peers were attending coaching classes and paying lakhs of rupees for their chance at the services, Kumar was studying at home, having opted for subjects—history and public administration—he was comfortable with. Things didn't get any easier when he reached the institute. One of the 45 candidates to have cleared the civil services examination in the Hindi medium in the 2006 batch, he realised his biggest weakness was his